imposed. Yet, what the Lahore report now seemed to suggest was that this had been to no avail because, after the unrest of 1919, ‘there is one effect which every Englishman feels in his bones, and that is that there is a change in his feeling towards the native of India’. So much so that, ‘[h]e now realizes that East is East and West is West’. The conviction of this belief arose from the fact that both ‘[t]he educated classes and the townsfolk have shown their hands. They have at once shown to the Englishman that he is in a land of an inferior civilisation, among a people which has not yet advanced beyond medievalism’. This alleged realization by the Englishman was significant because ‘[a]t anytime he may have to treat them as enemies’ and that ‘[i]t is idle to refuse to look facts in the face and to pretend that the situation remains unaltered’. The inference that the commissioner in Lahore drew from this assessment was that ‘[t]hese reflections will inevitably weaken the English official’s enthusiasm, and will incline him to leave the country at the earliest opportunity’.[5] What is manifestly plain from this report is a clear recognition by the British administration that the 1919 insurgency was no different from the first war of Indian Independence in 1857. This was despite the fact that in 1919 they still had ‘the loyal attitude of the troops; and the fact that the disaffected elements were not those from which the recruits were drawn’.[6] In fact, it was openly accepted that ‘[i]t is curious that fire-arms were never used by the rebels’.[7]

The secret report from the ‘Amritsar District’ on the disturbances in Amritsar in 1919 was no different from the one on Lahore when it recognized that although the ‘plots against the British Government in India’ had been ‘detected and suppressed’, what they successfully managed to do was that they ‘made men’s minds familiar with the possibility of that Government being overthrown’. It was almost as if a red line had been passed, and the Rubicon had been crossed, to the point of no return. The view from Amritsar was that ‘the great herd of the people had, so to speak, their heads up and when they have their heads up it is not far to a stampede’.[8] Four clear sources could be identified in the reports for this concern.